> “COULD WE GET A GOOD REGULAR ARMY, WE SHOULD SOON CLEAR THE COUNTRY OF THESE DAMNED INVADERS.”
>
> **THOMAS NELSON** WRITING TO THOMAS JEFFERSON, 1777

coats, blankets, or even shoes. When supply problems were at their worst, men were reduced to living off flour-and-water “firecakes”. Camped for the winter at Valley Forge, Pennsylvania, in 1777–78, the army reached extremes of privation. Yet it was here that the army at last began to come together as a disciplined force, under the direction of Prussian mercenary officer Baron Friedrich Wilhelm von Steuben. He drilled the men daily, raised morale, cracked down on unruly behaviour, and reduced disease by improving cleanliness and sanitation.

The problems of supply and payment were never solved. There was another major crisis in the winter of 1780–81 when those who had enrolled for three years in 1777 wanted to quit. Mutinies in the Pennsylvania and New Jersey regiments had to be suppressed in January 1781. But Washington succeeded in keeping his army in existence. A measure of the success of the Continental Army, despite all difficulties, is the admiration for American troops expressed by foreign observers. Baron von Closen, a member of the French expeditionary force sent to aid the American rebels, wrote: “It is incredible that soldiers composed of men of every age, even of children of 15, of whites and blacks, almost naked, unpaid, and rather poorly fed, can march so well and withstand fire so steadfastly.” The British surrender at Yorktown in October 1781 was a triumph for an army once dismissed by British General John Burgoyne as a “rabble in arms”.



Valley Forge
In the grim winter of 1777–78, Washington believed that his Continental Army must “starve, dissolve, or disperse, in order to obtain subsistence”. But, in the end, it survived, all the stronger for the experience of shared hardship.



A disciplined volley
The ideal to which George Washington aspired – a disciplined, smartly dressed, European-style army – was never achieved by the whole army, although certain units did their leader proud.

MINUTEMEN



The Battle of Lexington
The first shots of the war were fired across the village green at Lexington, Massachusetts. A confused encounter watched by spectators standing along the road, it ended with eight of the American minutemen lying dead.

The only forces at the disposal of the American colonies at the start of their rebellion were militia. There was a long-established tradition that all male citizens had a duty to turn out with a weapon for the defence of their colony or local community when required. In 1774, in the colony of Massachusetts, the original focus of the rebellion, a proportion of the militia were designated “minutemen”. Usually younger unmarried citizens, they elected officers for their companies and pledged to be available for action at a minute’s notice. The first shots of the war, at Lexington and Concord in April 1775, were exchanged between minutemen and British soldiers. At Concord the minutemen got the better of a smaller force of British regulars and pursued them back to Boston.

THE ROLE OF THE MILITIAS

In all the rebel colonies, colonial militias turned into state militias under rebel control, with all loyalists expelled. At times state militias competed with the Continental Army for resources, but the militias also provided essential short-term draftees to bolster the army’s ranks and auxiliary units to fight alongside the regulars.

Although militia training improved during the war, these part-time soldiers fresh from the workshop and the plough rarely stood up to British troops in open battle. Yet in spite of a reputation for running away when the fighting was hot, they performed invaluable service as security forces, ensuring the success of the rebellion at local level by manning garrisons and suppressing the activities of loyalists.